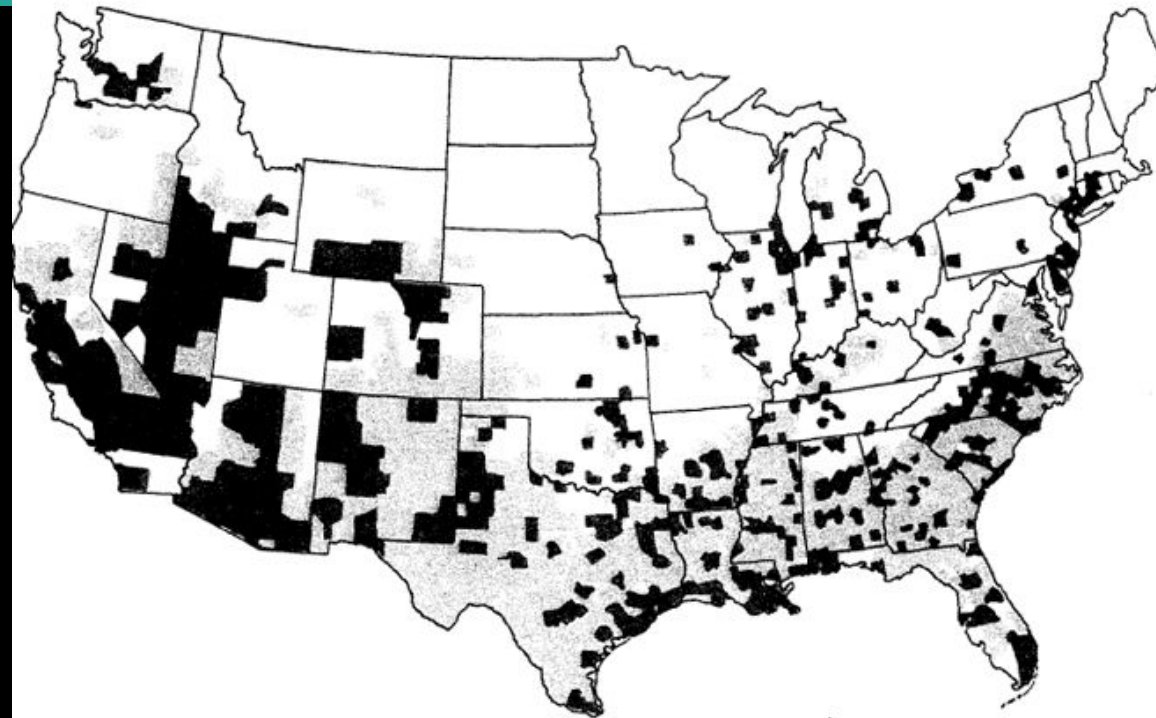


Environmental Racism

—
Kaelyn Howard, Snigdha Gurram, and Samantha Wood

TOXIC WASTES AND RACE In The United States



Introduction

Thesis/Argument: Marginalized communities (BIPOC, low-income) continue to bear the brunt of industrial waste being dumped into their neighborhoods.

Definition of Environmental Racism: refers to any environmental policy, practice, or directive that differentially affects [disproportionate impact] of disadvantages (whether intended or unintended) individuals, groups, or communities based on race or color

Definition of Environmental Justice: defined as the fair treatment and meaningful involvement of all people regardless of race, color, national origin, or income with respect to the development, implementation, and enforcement of environmental laws, regulations, and policies

Environmental Justice

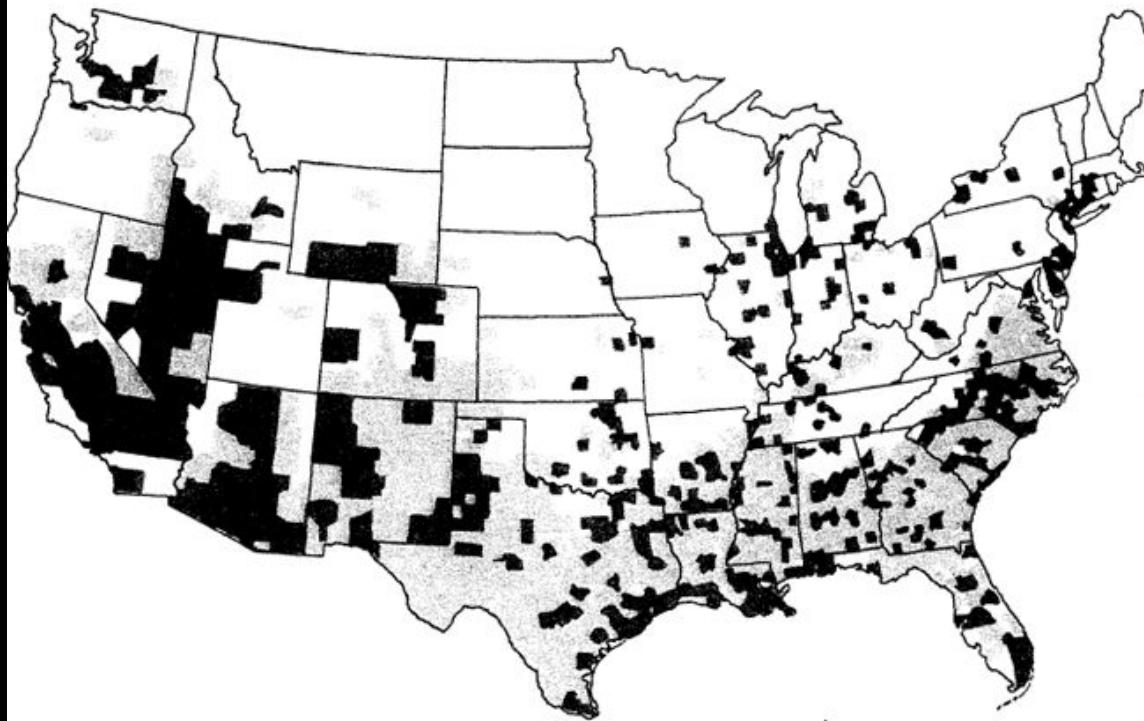


Environmental Justice: Grassroots Activism and Its Impact on Public Policy Decision Making

*“The protests also led the Commission for Racial Justice (1987) to produce **Toxic Wastes and Race in the United States**, the first national study to correlate waste facility sites and demographic characteristics. **Race was found to be the most potent variable in predicting where these facilities were located—more powerful than poverty, land values, and home ownership,**” (Bullard and Johnson).*

TOXIC WASTES AND RACE

In The United States



2 examples of communities affected by environmental racism:

Flint, Michigan

Savannah, Georgia

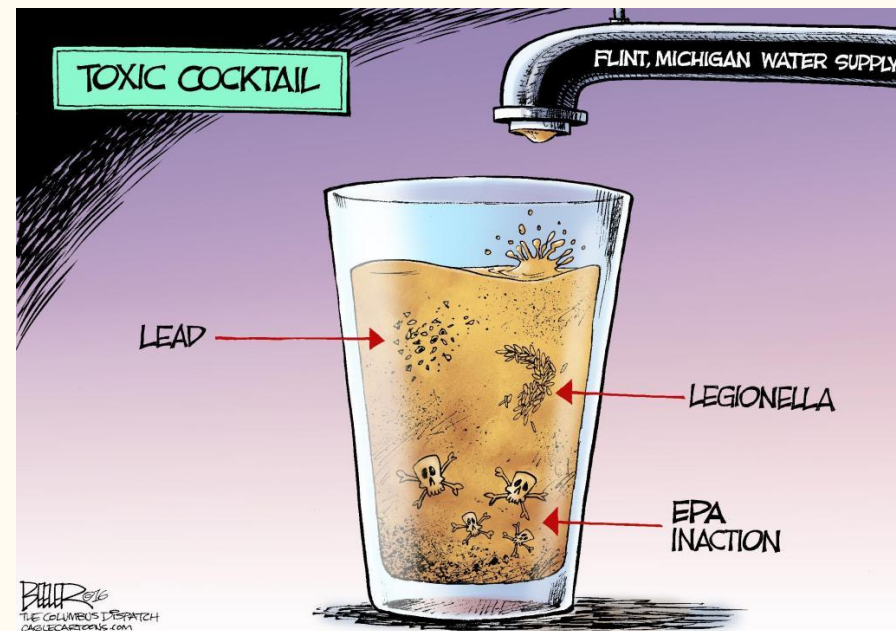


Savannah, Georgia



Flint, Michigan as of 2023

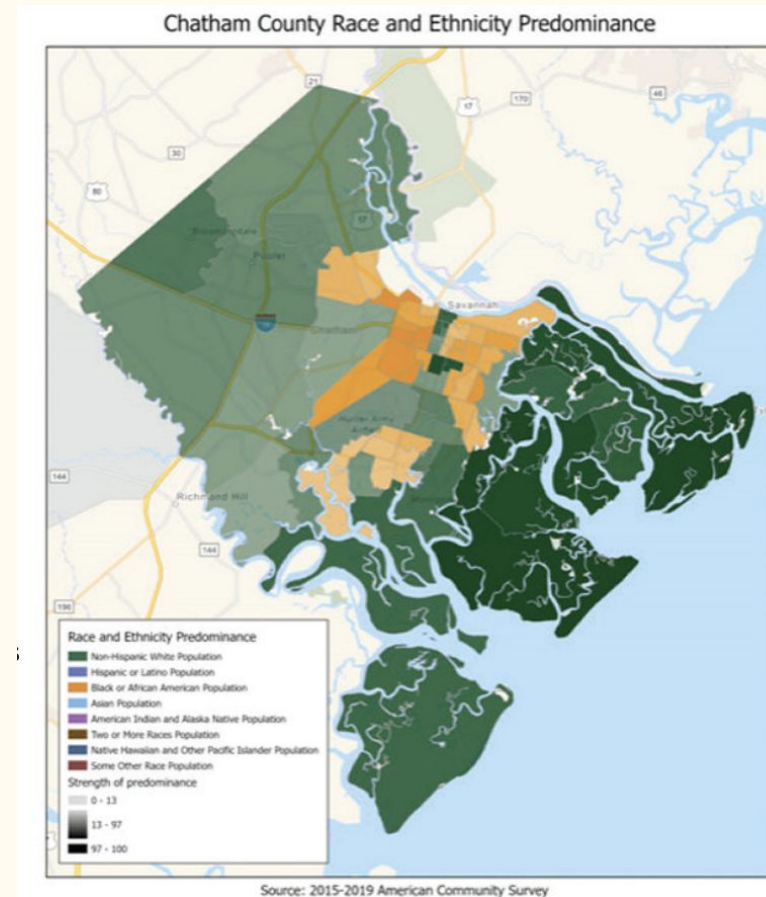
- Genesee County, Michigan
- Mid west
- 12th largest city in Michigan & 452nd largest city in the U.S.
- Population: 79,494
- Demographics:
 - Black/African American: 54.04%
 - White: 38.45%
 - Two or more race: 5.96%
- Average household income: \$39,575
- Poverty rate: 46.03%



Savannah, Georgia as of 2023

- Chatham County, Georgia
- South
- 4th largest city Georgia & 181st largest city in the U.S.
- Population: 145, 870
- Demographics:
 - Black/African American: 54.39%
 - White: 38.05%
 - 2 or more races: 2.89%
- Average household income: \$63,984
- Poverty rate: 23.08%

Savannah Report by The Racial Equity and Leadership Task Force



Health issues seen in these communities:

Flint, Michigan:

- Outbreak of Legionnaire disease
- Lead poisoning
- Behavior concerns of residents in Flint
 - residents had “feeling of anxiety or depression and substance abuse”

Savannah, Georgia:

- Asthma
- Respiratory diseases
- Lung cancer
- Lead poisoning

Solutions:

- Individual:
 - More attention must be drawn to these communities to conclude the ongoing issue.
 - More awareness of other similar situations in the United States.
- Society:
 - Educate communities about environmental issues.
 - Be aware of *where* the issues are taking place.
 - Be aware of *which* communities are being affected the most.

Strengths and Weaknesses

Strengths:

- Community members/general public become informed
- Communities can organize to fight for change

Weaknesses:

- Realization of the gravity of these situations can impact mental health/outlook
- Protesting may not make a difference

General Impacts of Pollution on Health

Three Main Areas:

Water

Air

Land



Water

- According to WHO, contaminated water can lead to health concerns like:
 - Ex. lead contamination
 - Cholera
 - Diarrhea
 - Dysentery
 - Hepatitis A
 - Polio

Air

- According to WHO, air pollution can cause increase health problems like:
 - Ex. VOC, PM 10, and PM 2.5
 - Respiratory infections
 - Heart disease
 - Lung cancer
 - Already ill, elderly, and poor are more susceptible

Land

- The environment at large is being impacted from the vast amounts of hazardous waste.
 - Polluted soil: loss of fertile land and reduction in possible food source
 - If ingested, food grown in location can cause health problems
 - Physically being surrounded by a toxic environment lead to short and long term health side effects
 - Kidney and liver damage
 - Nervous system damage
 - Neuromuscular blockade

General Impacts of Pollution on Health Solutions

- Individual:
 - People need to be proactive with solutions to problem with the government that is meant to protect them.
 - Ex. join campaigns or donate
- Society:
 - Care more about environment, not only enforce but empower and educated communities because epa does not have enough power over corporations.
 - Representative from community advocating for change at local level

Strengths and Weaknesses

Strengths:

- Communities will know what is happening around them
- Work with local government

Weaknesses:

- Money is required in order to fulfill solutions
- Community should be willing to actually do it

The Environmental Protection Agency (EPA)

What It's Meant For:

- Created on July 9, 1970
- Tasked with administering environmental assessment, research, and education.

Present Day:

- Loosening of existing regulations
- Suppressing reports from reputable sources to bury important news from the public
- Companies utilizing loopholes to create subpar products



EPA's Ineffectiveness

- Under funded
- Under resourced
- Does not have the political clout to improve agency
- Does not have authority to go after the organizations that exacerbate the problem



Environmental Protection Agency

Solutions:

- Individual:
 - Protesting against nearby organizations being a hazard to the environment and being more involved in the community to combat against toxicity and spreading awareness about the issue.
- Society:
 - The government needs to oversee the EPA so that the problem can be addressed and additional action can be taken in helping neighborhoods that have already been deeply affected.
 - As a collective, we need to be more educated and conscious about the problem and be more proactive about protecting the environment.

Strengths and Weaknesses

Strengths:

- People in these communities can see that their own health problems and use it as evidence to make correlations between the environmental waste being the cause to their physical and mental well-being
- People within these areas will be more insistent and involved in city administration

Weaknesses:

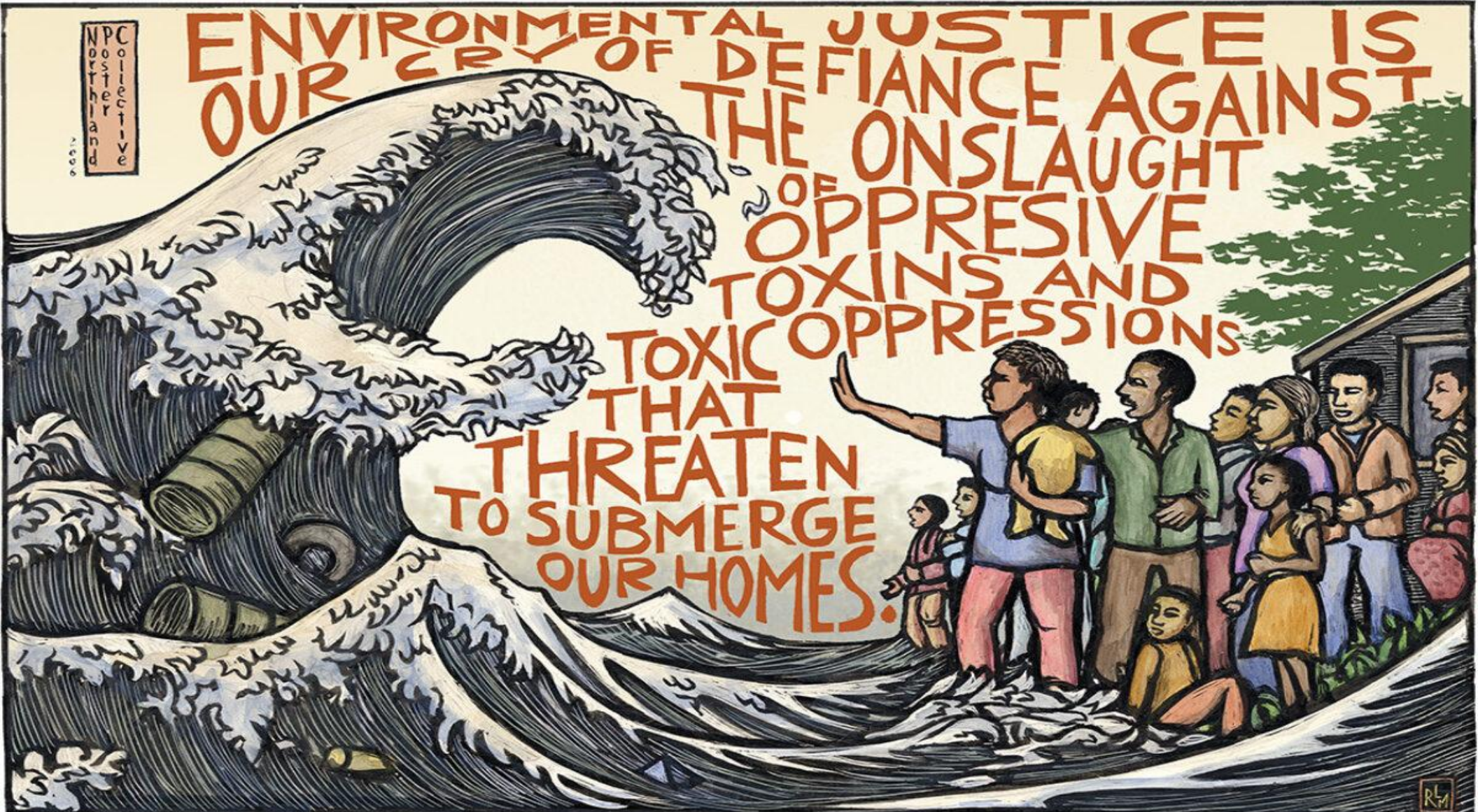
- Places accountability on the people instead of an organization that is suppose to act in their self interests
- Political clout may not be on the community's side

What does this says about our Society's Values and Principles?:

- People do not value the lives of minoritized communities compared to the Majority/Caucasians of Americans.
- Profit > People
- The values at stake are compassion, integrity, and respect for the community that is being affected for the long period of time.

NPC
collective
poster
land

ENVIRONMENTAL JUSTICE IS
OUR CRY OF DEFIANCE AGAINST
THE ONSLAUGHT
OF OPPRESSIVE
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RLM

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